Thereafter, there is a general discussion on three or four topics identified in advance. Even as this format allows for a more structured discussion, the sheer size of the meeting makes it unwieldy for active engagement on any specific issue. Also, since the meeting proceedings are recorded and its minutes are kept, it remains formal and somewhat choreographed.

Partly to compensate for this, the IMF has introduced a new event on the regular schedule—a breakfast meeting—bringing together finance ministers and central bank governors from systemically important countries and large economies, about thirty to thirty-five in all, along with the managing director of the IMF, the president of the World Bank and their senior deputies, for a freewheeling discussion on the global economic and financial situation. This meeting is informal, more participative and engaging, and decidedly more interesting than the formal IMFC meeting that follows this breakfast meeting. While Chidambaram attended these meetings, Pranab Mukherjee usually chose to skip them, and I often found myself to be the sole representative of India. I profited from these breakfast meetings, both for the insights into global policy issues and the opportunity to present emerging-market perspectives.

Neither the formal IMFC meeting nor the informal breakfast meeting was ever acrimonious, but one could easily sense undercurrents of strain on certain issues. In terms of these undercurrents, there was a clear distinction between the earlier period (2008–10) when the global financial crisis dominated the agenda and the later period (2011–12) when the eurozone sovereign debt crisis was the focus of these meetings. In the earlier period, America was at the receiving end of the blame for the economic and financial turmoil it foisted on the world because of its poor policies and loose regulation. Except on QE, a topic to which I will return later, on most other issues, the American tendency was generally not to contest the blame. It was instead more pragmatic: ‘OK, let’s put that behind us and see how we should move on.’ The Europeans, in contrast, were given to vehemently pushing back on any suggestion of blame for the spillover impact of their sovereign debt crisis or of their ineptitude in managing it. Nor did they